



Security Watch

High Alert!

"Extremely critical" vulnerabilities, as rated by security firm Secunia, have been reported in Microsoft Word and in Microsoft Office. The two vulnerabilities work differently. The vulnerability in Word is being actively exploited as of the time of writing. A successful exploit means the hacker can execute arbitrary code on your system.

The Word vulnerability affects Word 2000 and Word 2002. It is caused due to an unspecified error when parsing Word documents.

There has been no patch released thus far for the Word exploit, and until one comes along, you just need to make sure not to open untrusted Office documents.

As regards the other vulnerabilities, in Office, one of them is being actively exploited via Excel.

In fact, there is a long list of software affected by these vulnerabilities, and to find if your product is affected, you should visit <http://tinyurl.com/398gkg>. Both vulnerabilities are exposed when processing "malformed records."

Patches have been released by Microsoft, and you should apply the appropriate one.

For Office 2000 SP3:
<http://tinyurl.com/yugfes>

For Office XP SP3:
<http://tinyurl.com/2fgw43>

Office 2003 SP2:
<http://tinyurl.com/2gd5x4>

Microsoft Office 2004 for Mac:
www.microsoft.com/mac/

latest DirectX 10 capable cards.

For the first gamer segment, switching to Vista right now may be a problem, and kind of pointless. The reason is simple: what Vista brings to the table is DX10 compatibility, which the next generation of games will run on. If you're going to be running DX9, it's perhaps best you do it on the operating system it was designed for.

For the top-of-the-line-or-nothing-else gamer, Vista is probably what you should be looking at for future-proofing. That said, before thinking of switching to Vista, make sure your hardware manufacturer's are making Vista drivers—this is for *all* your hardware.

The majority of Indian PC gamers will probably play it smart with the wait and watch game, which isn't such a bad idea—at least until some good DX10 games come out and all the initial teething problems for Vista are solved. For now, just watch the Vista news flashes on various sites, all the benchmarks, and chuckle contentedly.

THE RUSSIAN PERSPECTIVE

MS To Blame For Piracy?

Russia is amongst the top 10 nations responsible for using pirated software. According

Vietnam	90%
Zimbabwe	90%
Indonesia	87%
China	86%
Pakistan	86%
Kazakhstan	85%
Ukraine	85%
Cameroon	84%
Russia	83%
Bolivia	83%

to studies conducted by Business Software Alliance (www.bsa.org), 83 per cent of computers sold in Russia run on pirated software. Incidentally, the top ten pirated-software countries are as in the table above.

Russian IT Minister Dmitry Milovantsev recently said that the cause of high piracy rates in Russia was more the fault of software vendors than of the users! Now that may sound like a really tall claim, and a lot of you will be going, "Oh no, not another person moaning about how Microsoft should take into account the earnings of the average Russian!" Do Russians really want a crippled version of XP, like the one India saw a few years ago? Will the Russian public pay to have a Windows version that only allows three windows to open at a time, especially when the "free" version that's available from the local market costs almost nothing and gives you full functionality? It's an old debate, and we're not going to get into that...

Those of you who want to sit down and start shooting off an e-mail to

HOT

Vista



It's not selling as much as Windows XP did when it launched, but it is doing well. Of course, this could be because Windows XP had the advantage of moving users away from Windows 98 and Windows Me, and even pirates paid to move from those two...

Vista Upgrades

More people are buying Vista with new computers than upgrading from XP. This is because of the all new heavy hardware requirements—and don't tell us that Vista runs on lower requirements without Aero... Vista without Aero is... err... Windows XP?



Mr Milovantsev and point out that open source is always a viable alternative might want to hold off hitting "Send" on that pirated Outlook window for a while... apparently, in a bid to reduce piracy, Microsoft does not allow hardware partners to sell computers without Windows loaded. So Russians have no choice but to buy from smaller assemblers or fork out the cost of the Windows OS that's preloaded on their machine.

But the bit that really stinks is that if you buy from these PC manufacturers, still insist on using an Open Source OS, and do *not* want Windows loaded, you have to shell out an *extra* \$50 to



One Silly Question

"How many GBs is your brain?"



"Unlimited"
Sanket Shankar



"80 GB, enough for me!"
Sameer Rahate



"My OS doesn't run on GBs!"
Jinal Kamdar



"200 GB and upgradable"
Ravi Prabhakar



"Too much for my RAM to handle!"
Ekta Modi